# Parshas Beha'aloscha

*Lighting the World Without Losing Ourselves*

*Menorah · Pesach Sheni · Shevet Dan · Kel Na Refa Na Lah*

## I. A Personal Question Before the Parsha

Another exciting week. Another Erev Shabbos where life is moving fast and we are trying to get done what needs to get done before Shabbos arrives and reminds us once again who we really are.

This week I had a she'eilah for Rav Channen that I want to share, because it connects directly to everything this week's parsha is about. I work in application security, and next week I am traveling to London for a trade show. My employers and my in-laws, who live in the UK and are very familiar with the safety realities on the ground there, asked me something that I was not expecting: please tuck in your tzitzis, please tuck in your peyos, blend in a little more. And I was genuinely torn by this. Not because I am ashamed of being Jewish, chas v'shalom. Not because I am afraid. But because I am also a family man, a husband, a father, and a businessman who lives in the real world. Pikuach nefesh is not an abstraction. Safety matters.

So I brought it to Rav Channen. And what he said helped me see it clearly. He said that people are watching, and because they are watching, how I respond matters. I could push back and tuck nothing in, and maybe some of that is real emunah and bitachon that Hashem provides parnassah and protects us. But Rav Channen was honest that sometimes what looks like courage is actually gaavah dressed up as bitachon. And there is another way to think about it entirely. When I am in the business world as a frum Jew, I have an opportunity to show my colleagues that we take pikuach nefesh seriously. That we keep kashrus. That we maintain shomer negiah. That we make time for tefillah. That we do not use foul language even when joking around with clients. That we operate with integrity. That itself is being an or la'amim, a light to the nations. Not by making a statement, but by being an example. And that leads us directly into this week's parsha.

## II. Beha'aloscha: Light That Rises on Its Own

Parshas Beha'aloscha opens with the mitzvah of lighting the menorah:

בְּהַעֲלֹתְךָ אֶת הַנֵּרֹת

*"When you raise up the lamps."*
*— Bamidbar 8:2*

Rashi explains that the flame must be lit until it rises and burns on its own. That detail is not incidental. It is the entire lesson. Real light is not forced. Real growth is not a performance. The job of the one who lights is to kindle something that then takes on a life of its own. The menorah stood inside the Mishkan, a private and sacred space, and yet its light radiated outward toward the world. Kedushah that is genuine always moves in that direction, from the inside out.

This is what Rav Channen was pointing at with the London question. The or la'amim is not about visibility for its own sake. It is not about making sure people can see the tzitzis from across the street. It is about whether the flame is real. If the flame is real, it will be felt. If it is not real, no amount of external display will make it so. The goal is to kindle something inside, and then let it rise on its own.

## III. Moshe Did Not Know, and That Was the Point

The parsha then gives us something that should stop us cold. The menorah was to be made from a single piece of beaten gold, mikshah achas, one unified form. And Chazal teach us that Moshe Rabbeinu struggled to understand exactly how to make it. He looked at the instructions and he did not know what to do.

Moshe Rabbeinu. The one who spoke with Hashem panim el panim. The greatest prophet who ever lived. He did not understand what he was supposed to do, and he said so. He asked for help. He did not get frustrated and force his way through. He did not pretend to understand. He simply asked.

Rabbi Yehoshua Gordon, zichrono livrachah, used to say in his shiurim: if all else fails, follow the instructions. And I would add, as this parsha teaches us, that if you do not understand the instructions, you ask. That is not weakness. That is the exact quality that makes a person capable of receiving siyata d'Shmaya. The ability to stop and say, I do not know, I need help, is itself one of the highest madreigos. Most people are far too afraid to

say it. Moshe Rabbeinu, the greatest of all, modeled it for us so we would know it is not only permitted but necessary.

## IV. Lamah Nigraeh: Asking From a Healthy Place

Later in the parsha we encounter one of the most emotionally powerful moments in the entire Torah. A group of Jews comes to Moshe because they were unable to bring the Korban Pesach. They had become tamei meis. The mefarshim explain that according to one opinion, these were the individuals carrying the bones of Yosef HaTzadik out of Mitzrayim, fulfilling the oath that had been made generations earlier. They became tamei through a mitzvah. And yet they still felt left out. They felt the pain of watching everyone around them move forward while they stood on the outside.

That feeling is deeply human. A person can be doing exactly what they are supposed to be doing and still feel behind, still feel disconnected, still feel like something is being taken from them. The question is what they do with that feeling. This group did not become bitter. They did not walk away, did not turn resentment into rebellion. They came to Aharon first, then to Moshe, the two of them sitting and learning together, and they asked their question with respect and with honesty:

לָמָּה נִגָּרַע

*"Why should we lose out?"*

*— Bamidbar 9:7*

And Moshe Rabbeinu did exactly what he did with the menorah. He said, I do not know, let me ask Hashem. And Hashem said: they are right. Because they had the koach to ask honestly, from an emotionally healthy place, without resentment and without giving up, a new halacha was born. Pesach Sheni. A second chance, written into Torah itself, because people asked the right question in the right way. What an unbelievable lesson. Sometimes the path forward is created by the honest question. The asking itself opens the door.

## V. Shevet Dan and the Broken Luchos

As Klal Yisrael traveled through the desert, Shevet Dan traveled at the very back of the camp. Every other shevet went ahead of them. And the job of Shevet Dan was to move

behind everyone and make sure nothing and no one was left behind. Lost objects. Stragglers. The people who could not keep up. Dan was the one who gathered them in.

That is an enormous tafkid. It is not glamorous. Nobody is watching the back of the camp and cheering. But without someone back there, things get lost. People get lost. Being last does not mean being beaten. Being at the back does not mean having less value. It means having a specific job that nobody else can do from that position. If you are the last one picked for the team, you were still picked. You are still there. And there are responsibilities that exist only at the back that the people in the front cannot fulfill.

The Torah also tells us that as the camp traveled, the Aron went with them. And in that Aron were not only the second luchos, the whole ones, but also the shards of the first luchos, the ones that Moshe had broken at the Eigel HaZahav. The broken pieces were not discarded. They were carried. They traveled with Klal Yisrael through the desert, right alongside the whole ones, because even broken luchos carry kedushah. Even something that appears shattered is not worthless. The question is always what direction the brokenness pushes us. Toward humility and growth and deeper dependence on Hashem, or toward bitterness and resentment and giving up? The Aron held both. Both traveled together. That is the Torah's answer.

## VI. The Slav: Looking Backward

And then the tone of the parsha shifts sharply. After all of this elevation, after the menorah and the honest questions and Pesach Sheni and the traveling Aron, the nation begins to complain. They want meat. They remember Egypt. They say that in Mitzrayim they had fish, cucumbers, melons, onions, garlic. They are nostalgic for slavery.

This is one of the most psychologically honest moments in the Torah. There is no such thing as a free lunch. In Egypt, Klal Yisrael was enslaved, oppressed, broken, and degraded. Their children were murdered. And yet when the present becomes difficult, when the desert is hot and the manna is all there is, the mind reaches backward toward what felt familiar, even if what felt familiar was suffering. People can romanticize their own pain when growth feels too hard. That is the danger of looking backward instead of forward. The Torah is not criticizing human emotion here. It is naming it honestly and asking us to see it for what it is. Emotional honesty with ourselves, knowing when we are glorifying the past because the present is difficult, is one of the central avodas of this sefer.

## VII. Miriam and the Limits of Judgment

Toward the end of the parsha comes the story of Miriam speaking critically about Moshe Rabbeinu regarding his separation from his wife. And this needs to be handled carefully, because Miriam was not a petty person. She was a neviah, a prophetess, a towering figure in Klal Yisrael. What she said about Moshe was not malicious gossip. It came from a framework of genuine Torah values, from an understanding that there is a mitzvah involved in the relationship between husband and wife. From her frame of reference, she had a legitimate point.

But Moshe was not operating inside a normal frame of reference. Hashem Himself testifies that Moshe's level of nevuah was categorically different from every other prophet. The standard that applied to every other human being simply did not apply to Moshe in the same way. And Miriam did not know the full picture. She was judging from incomplete information, through her own lens, about a reality she could not fully access. And the result was tzaraas, a physical manifestation of an internal spiritual misalignment. Chazal are not telling us that Miriam was a bad person. They are telling us that even the greatest people, when they judge others without full understanding, can fall into something that pulls them lower. How often do we do the same? How often do we look at another person's choices, another person's tafkid, another person's relationship with Hashem, and conclude that we know better? This story is a reminder to be careful.

## VIII. Kel Na Refa Na Lah

And then we reach the close of the parsha, and Moshe Rabbeinu's response to seeing his sister struck with tzaraas. He could have said anything. He could have offered a lengthy tefillah, invoked multiple names of Hashem, performed something dramatic and powerful. He was, after all, Moshe Rabbeinu.

Instead, he said five words:

אֵ֖ל נָ֣א רְפָ֣א נָ֔א לָ֖הּ

*"Please, G-d, please heal her."*

*— Bamidbar 12:13*

That is it. No theatrics. No performance. Just sincerity, honesty, and directness. Heal her. The simplicity is the point. We spend so much time thinking that holiness has to sound

complicated, that a real tefillah has to be long and elaborate, that Hashem only listens if we say it perfectly. But Moshe Rabbeinu, the greatest of all, showed us that sometimes the most powerful thing a Jew can say is simply: Hashem, I need help. Please. That kind of honesty, stripped of ego and performance, goes straight up. And for Miriam to be healed as well, she needed to do the inner work of teshuvah, to genuinely reckon with what had happened. Both of them had their role in the process. Both were real. Both mattered.

## IX. What We Carry Into Shabbos

Parshas Beha'aloscha is asking us the same questions over and over in different forms. What is my tafkid right now? Am I willing to say I do not know and ask for help? Am I asking my questions from an emotionally healthy place, without resentment, or am I letting frustration pull me toward bitterness? Am I judging others without full knowledge of their reality? And when it is time to ask Hashem for something, can I keep it simple enough to be honest?

Whether it is the London question or a question about how to build the menorah or a question about why we should lose out, the Torah keeps showing us the same path. Name what is real. Ask honestly. Do not look backward when the present is hard. Recognize that the job at the back of the camp is as sacred as the job at the front. And when the path forward is not clear, say the five words. Hashem, please. I need help. Because He will show it to us. Of that much, we can be certain.

**חזק ואחזק**

*Good Shabbos*

---

## Reflection Questions

> - *What does it mean for me to be an or la'amim in my actual life right now, not in an abstract sense, but in my work, my relationships, and the specific world I move through every day?*
> - *Where am I afraid to say I do not know, or to ask for help? What would it take to follow Moshe Rabbeinu's example and simply ask?*
> - *Is there a place in my life where I feel left behind while doing exactly what I am supposed to be doing? Am I bringing that feeling to Hashem honestly, or letting it harden into resentment?*

- *Am I carrying broken things with kedushah, treating my own setbacks and failures as something still worth carrying, or have I discarded them as worthless?*
- *Where am I looking backward toward something familiar but unhealthy, and calling it longing? What would it mean to let that go and move forward?*
- *Is there someone in my life I am judging without full knowledge of their reality? What would it mean to give them the same benefit of the doubt I would want for myself?*